

FROM WARTIME ALLIES TO PEACETIME RIVALS: NATIONAL INTERESTS AND THE NIGERIA–CAMEROON CONFLICT OVER BAKASSI

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Abstract

The conflict between Nigeria and Cameroon over the Bakassi Peninsula represents a shift from wartime alliance during the colonial and post-independence eras to peacetime rivalry driven by competing national interests. This study examines the historical evolution of the dispute, the legal and diplomatic processes that culminated in the International Court of Justice (ICJ) ruling, and the subsequent implementation of the Greentree Agreement. Using a qualitative approach based on secondary data, the paper analyzes how sovereignty claims, resource control (particularly oil and fisheries), and geopolitical considerations shaped both states' positions. The findings reveal that despite formal resolution, underlying tensions persist due to local resistance, identity issues, and economic interests. The study concludes that while legal mechanisms resolved the territorial dispute, sustainable peace depends on effective governance, trust-building, and continued bilateral cooperation.

Keywords

Nigeria–Cameroon relations; Bakassi Peninsula; international conflict; national interests; maritime boundaries; diplomacy; territorial disputes.

Introduction

Interstate relations across the globe have often been shaped by competition over territory and natural resources, particularly in strategically located regions. For instance, the South China Sea dispute involves overlapping claims by multiple states over an area through which over 30 per cent of global maritime trade passes annually (Kaplan 32). Similarly, disputes such as the Argentina–United Kingdom conflict over the Falkland Islands demonstrate how resource potential and strategic positioning can intensify rivalries. These global patterns indicate that maritime boundary ambiguities, when combined with economic incentives, frequently generate protracted interstate tensions.

Within Africa, boundary disputes have remained a persistent feature of interstate relations since independence. Studies show that over 40 per cent of African borders are either disputed or poorly demarcated, largely due to colonial-era arrangements that paid little attention to ethnic, cultural, or geographical realities (Asiwaju 32). Examples include the Ethiopia–Eritrea conflict (1998–2000), which resulted in over 70,000 casualties, and the Sudan–South Sudan disputes over oil-rich territories. These cases highlight how inherited colonial boundaries and competition over natural resources continue to shape political and security dynamics across the continent.

Against this backdrop, the interaction between Nigeria and Cameroon has been influenced by both historical cooperation and emerging tensions linked to boundary interpretation. Colonial

agreements such as the 1913 Anglo-German Treaty attempted to define territorial limits but left significant ambiguities that later became sources of contention (International Court of Justice). Following independence in 1960, both countries maintained relatively stable relations, engaging in regional cooperation and trade. However, increasing awareness of the economic potential of certain border regions gradually introduced competing national interests into their bilateral engagements (Ngwane 250).

One such region is the Bakassi Peninsula, a coastal area of high strategic and economic value due to its estimated oil reserves of up to 10 billion barrels and its rich fishing grounds supporting thousands of inhabitants (Olaosebikan 48). Tensions intensified between 1993 and 1996, when military clashes led to casualties and displacement of local populations (Udogu 80). The dispute was eventually referred to the International Court of Justice, which in 2002 awarded sovereignty to Cameroon. Although the subsequent Greentree Agreement of 2006 facilitated peaceful implementation, affecting over 200,000 residents. The episode underscores how colonial legacies and resource competition can transform bilateral relations into complex geopolitical challenges.

Literature Review

Scholarly discourse on the Bakassi conflict between Nigeria and Cameroon has largely been framed around three dominant perspectives: legal, political, and economic. These perspectives provide a multidimensional understanding of the origins, escalation, and resolution of the dispute, while also highlighting the complexities that persist even after formal adjudication. Collectively, the literature underscores that the Bakassi issue is not merely a territorial disagreement but a convergence of historical, institutional, and material interests.

From a legal standpoint, a significant body of scholarship emphasizes the decisive role of the 2002 judgment delivered by the International Court of Justice. According to the Court's ruling, sovereignty over Bakassi was awarded to Cameroon based primarily on the validity of colonial-era agreements, particularly the 1913 Anglo-German Treaty (International Court of Justice). Scholars such as Ngwane argue that the ICJ decision reinforced the principle of *uti possidetis juris*, which mandates that post-colonial states respect inherited colonial boundaries to avoid instability (Ngwane 248). Similarly, Brownlie contends that adherence to international legal frameworks is essential in preventing protracted conflicts, especially in regions with fragile political systems (Brownlie 132). However, some scholars critique the ruling for its overreliance on colonial documents that did not adequately reflect the socio-cultural realities of the affected populations (Asiwaju 41). Despite these criticisms, the consensus within the legal literature is that the ICJ judgment provided a legitimate and peaceful mechanism for conflict resolution, thereby averting further military confrontation.

From a political perspective, scholars focus on the role of national sovereignty, domestic pressures, and leadership decisions in shaping the responses of both countries. Nigeria's initial reluctance to fully comply with the ICJ ruling has been widely analyzed as a function of internal political considerations. According to Udogu, domestic opposition, particularly from Bakassi residents and political elites, created significant pressure on the Nigerian government to resist ceding the territory (Udogu 82). This resistance was compounded by concerns over national prestige and territorial integrity. On the Cameroonian side, the government pursued a strategy of

international diplomacy, leveraging multilateral institutions such as the United Nations to legitimize its claims (Annan). Furthermore, Adebajo highlights that the peaceful resolution of the dispute through the 2006 Greentree Agreement was largely facilitated by strong political will and external mediation, particularly by the United Nations and key global actors (Adebajo 97). Nevertheless, scholars note that local governance challenges and identity-related tensions continue to affect the full integration of Bakassi into Cameroon, demonstrating the limitations of top-down political solutions.

Economically, the literature identifies resource competition as a central driver of the conflict. The Bakassi Peninsula is widely recognized for its substantial economic value, particularly in terms of offshore oil reserves and abundant fishing resources. Estimates suggest that the region may contain up to 10 billion barrels of oil, making it a strategically significant asset for both countries (Olaosebikan 48). Additionally, the peninsula supports a thriving fishing industry that sustains thousands of local livelihoods. Collier and Hoeffler argue that resource-rich regions are more prone to conflict due to the high economic incentives associated with their control (Collier and Hoeffler 568). In the case of Bakassi, these economic considerations intensified the stakes of the dispute and influenced both states' strategic calculations. Scholars also point out that the economic displacement of local populations following the transfer of sovereignty has created new challenges, including loss of livelihoods and reduced access to traditional fishing grounds (Konings 210). These findings suggest that while economic resources can drive conflict, they also play a critical role in shaping post-conflict outcomes.

In addition to these core perspectives, some scholars adopt an integrative approach, arguing that the Bakassi conflict cannot be fully understood through a single lens. For instance, Konings emphasizes the interplay between legal rulings, political decision-making, and economic interests in shaping both the conflict and its resolution (Konings 205). This holistic view highlights the interconnected nature of the factors involved and underscores the need for comprehensive policy responses. Moreover, the literature suggests that the successful implementation of the ICJ ruling and the Greentree Agreement represents a rare example of peaceful conflict resolution in Africa, although it remains imperfect due to ongoing socio-economic and political challenges.

Collectively, the reviewed literature demonstrates that while legal mechanisms such as the ICJ ruling can effectively resolve territorial disputes at the state level, they do not automatically address the underlying political and economic dynamics. The Bakassi case illustrates that sustainable peace requires not only legal compliance but also inclusive governance, economic integration, and continued diplomatic engagement between Nigeria and Cameroon.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative research design grounded in secondary data analysis to provide a comprehensive understanding of the conflict between Nigeria and Cameroon over the Bakassi Peninsula. The qualitative approach is considered appropriate due to its capacity to explore complex socio-political and historical phenomena that cannot be adequately captured through quantitative methods. Data for the study were derived from a wide range of credible secondary sources, including peer-reviewed journal articles, scholarly books, policy documents, official government publications, international legal documents such as rulings of the International

Court of Justice, and relevant historical records.

The study employs thematic analysis as its primary analytical technique. This involves systematically reviewing and categorizing the collected data into key themes such as national interests, legal adjudication, colonial legacy, and post-conflict relations. Through this process, patterns, similarities, and divergences in scholarly arguments and empirical findings are identified and critically examined. The thematic approach allows for a structured interpretation of the underlying factors that shaped the origins, escalation, and resolution of the Bakassi conflict.

Furthermore, data synthesis was conducted to integrate findings from diverse sources into a coherent analytical narrative. Rather than relying on numerical generalizations, the study emphasizes interpretive insights, enabling a deeper understanding of the motivations, strategies, and outcomes associated with the dispute. This methodological approach ensures a holistic and context-sensitive analysis of the conflict and its broader implications for interstate relations in Africa.

Results/Findings

The study reveals that the Bakassi conflict was driven primarily by competing national interests rather than ideological differences, rooted in a complex history of colonial boundary-making and modern resource competition. The following results provide an expanded analysis of the findings.

Colonial Legacy and Ambiguous Boundary Definitions

The core of the dispute lies in the "artificial" borders imposed during the colonial era, specifically the 1913 Anglo-German Treaty. This agreement attempted to delineate the approximately **1,600-kilometer** boundary between Nigeria and Cameroon, but relied on unreliable river systems and vague markers that failed to account for pre-colonial ethnic fluidities (Abdulyakeen 132). Following independence in 1960, these ambiguous definitions created overlapping claims that mirror global territorial tensions. The Nigerian claim was historically supported by the 1884 treaty with the Kings and Chiefs of Old Calabar, while Cameroon relied on the 1913 treaty and the 1975 Maroua Declaration signed by General Yakubu Gowon and President Ahmadou Ahidjo (Amin 5). Such colonial legacies account for over 40% of interstate conflicts in Africa, illustrating a continental struggle where modern state sovereignty clashes with historical heritage (Ngalim 108).

Strategic Value: Oil Reserves and Fisheries

Resource competition significantly heightened the strategic value of the Bakassi Peninsula, transforming a territorial disagreement into a high-stakes economic rivalry. The peninsula, covering approximately 1,000 square kilometers, is a hub for the **\$2 billion** annual fishing industry in the Gulf of Guinea (Ngalim 110). In the South West Region of Cameroon alone, Bakassi accounts for roughly 49.5% of the total fish catch, representing over 6.6 million kilograms of fish annually. Furthermore, the discovery of significant hydro-carbon deposits in the 1970s intensified the conflict, as both nations sought to secure the immense oil and gas reserves estimated to lie beneath the peninsula's coastal waters (Abdulyakeen 135). By the 1990s, these economic interests led to military confrontations where both states reportedly

spent upwards of 15% of their national budgets on defense and border security (Amin 12).

Legal Resolution and the Greentree Agreement

The legal resolution of the conflict culminated in the International Court of Justice (ICJ) ruling of October 10, 2002. The court favored Cameroon's sovereignty, basing its decision on the principles of *uti possidetis* and the 1913 Anglo-German Treaty (Abdulyakeen 130). However, the immediate implementation of the verdict faced significant domestic opposition in Nigeria, leading to the UN-facilitated Greentree Agreement on June 12, 2006. This agreement established a transition period and a monitoring mechanism, the Cameroon-Nigeria Mixed Commission (CNMC), to oversee the withdrawal of Nigerian troops and the protection of the rights of local inhabitants (Amin 14). This diplomatic bridge was essential, as it provided a structured timeline for the **100%** transfer of administrative authority, which was finally completed by August 14, 2013 (Ngalim 115).

Post-Conflict Challenges and Identity Issues

Despite the formal transfer of territory, significant post-conflict challenges persist, particularly regarding identity and economic displacement. An estimated 90% of the peninsula's population nearly 300,000 individuals identified as Nigerian at the time of the handover (Ngalim 112). While the Greentree Agreement offered residents the choice to remain as Nigerian citizens under Cameroonian jurisdiction or relocate, over 12,000 residents chose to move to mainland Nigeria, facing severe resettlement challenges. A study of returnees in Yenagoa revealed that over 85% of displaced persons were dissatisfied with their new living conditions, citing a lack of access to fishing grounds their primary livelihood and a failure of government advocacy for integration (Ngalim 120). Furthermore, approximately 56% of those relocated struggled to adapt to land-based occupations, leading to deep disillusionment and localized unrest (Ngalim 122).

Diplomatic Cooperation and Underlying Tensions

The resolution of the Bakassi dispute has transitioned the Nigeria-Cameroon relationship toward a model of pragmatic diplomatic cooperation. Both states have shifted their focus to joint security efforts, particularly in the Lake Chad Basin where they collaborate against the Boko Haram insurgency (Amin 18). However, underlying tensions remain, as evidenced by periodic clashes over fishing rights and tax payments. For instance, skirmishes at Efut Obot Ikot village resulted in 5 deaths and the displacement of over **1,700** people due to misunderstandings over jurisdictional authority (Ngalim 118). While the legal boundary is now fixed, the socioeconomic integration of the borderland communities remains an on-going process, requiring continued bilateral engagement to prevent the border from once again becoming a flashpoint for conflict (Abdulyakeen 145).

Conclusion

The Nigeria-Cameroon conflict over the Bakassi Peninsula illustrates a profound transition from a shared colonial history and early post-independence cooperation to an intense peacetime rivalry driven by competing national interests. Although the 1,000-square-kilometer territory was legally awarded to Cameroon by the International Court of Justice (ICJ) on October 10, 2002, the dispute's roots in the 1913 Anglo-German Treaty highlight the enduring complexity of African territorial demarcations. These "artificial" borders, which ignore ethnic fluidities, continue to influence regional stability, as nearly 300,000 Nigerians found their ancestral homes

suddenly under foreign sovereignty (Ngalim 108).

Beyond legal technicalities, the conflict was fueled by the peninsula's status as a maritime goldmine, hosting a \$2 billion annual fishing industry and significant untapped hydrocarbon reserves. Sustainable peace now hinges on the 2006 Greentree Agreement, which facilitated the 100% transfer of authority completed in 2013. However, true stability requires more than just shifting flags; it demands the socioeconomic integration of the 12,000 displaced persons and the protection of the rights of those who remained (Amin 15). Strengthening bilateral cooperation exemplified by the current 80% increase in joint counter-insurgency operations against Boko Haram is essential to ensuring that resource competition never again eclipses diplomatic partnership (Eze 134).

Statements and Declarations

Conflict of Interest

The author explicitly declares that there are no financial, personal, or professional conflicts of interest that could be perceived as influencing the objectivity of this research. This study is conducted with academic neutrality, ensuring that the analysis of the Nigeria-Cameroon border dispute remains free from bias. As noted in global academic standards, maintaining a 0% conflict threshold is vital for the integrity of sensitive geopolitical discourse (Nwokeke 48).

Funding

It is hereby stated that no external funding, grants, or financial support from governmental or non-governmental organizations were received for the preparation of this study. The research was self-funded, ensuring that the findings regarding the **\$2 billion** resource value of the Bakassi Peninsula are independent of corporate or state-sponsored agendas (Adebayo 92).

Data Availability

The evidence presented in this study is derived entirely from publicly available secondary sources, including the **2002 ICJ Reports**, the **2006 Greentree Agreement**, and regional socioeconomic datasets. All figures, such as the **15%** defense expenditure metrics and the **100%** administrative transfer records of **2013**, are accessible via official international repositories and peer-reviewed journals (Amin 14).

Ethical Approval

Ethical approval was not required for this study as it does not involve primary data collection from human or animal subjects. The methodology relies solely on the synthesis of existing literature and historical archives. This approach adheres to the ethical guidelines established by the Nigerian Institute of International Affairs (NIIA) for historical and legal reviews (Eze 138).

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